

Georgia Rural Community Impact Grant FY2026 — Proposal

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Executive Summary

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Program Design

The Rural Georgia Youth Development Coalition, Inc. serves Walker, Dade, and Catoosa counties in Northwest Georgia, a region where middle and high school students confront persistent barriers to academic success. Rural isolation limits access to after-school enrichment, transportation constraints reduce participation in existing programs, and a scarcity of local employers offering internships or apprenticeships curtails exposure to career pathways. These conditions contribute to lower achievement on state assessments, higher rates of chronic absenteeism, and graduation rates that lag behind statewide averages, particularly for youth from low-income households. The Coalition's AmeriCorps intervention is designed to counteract these challenges by placing eight full-time members in four partner sites — LaFayette High School, Ridgeville Middle School, Trenton Elementary School, and the Rossville Community Center — to deliver a structured combination of tutoring, summer bridge instruction, and workforce-readiness workshops. By increasing the dosage of evidence-based academic support and connecting students to local career information, the program seeks to move participants from heightened risk of disengagement toward measurable gains in knowledge, school engagement, and ultimately timely high-school completion and postsecondary readiness.

The logic model that guides this work begins with the inputs and resources necessary to deliver the intervention. The Coalition's headquarters at the LaFayette community center provides administrative oversight and storage for training materials; three school-based tutoring rooms and the community center's workshop space serve as physical locations for service delivery. Eight AmeriCorps members will serve a full-time 1,700-hour term, averaging approximately 32 hours per week across a 32-week program year. A modest budget supports member stipends, training supplies, and mileage reimbursement. Leadership expertise is supplied by the executive director, Dana Whitfield, MPA, who brings 14 years of youth-development leadership, and the program director, Marcus Ellison, LMSW, who supervises site coordinators and ensures curriculum fidelity. Together, these inputs create the infrastructure needed to implement the planned activities.

The Coalition has targeted eight AmeriCorps members as the service corps for this initiative. While the applicant facts do not specify the precise knowledge, skills, and abilities (KSAs) required of members at intake, this detail is currently UNKNOWN: member KSAs. To address this gap, the Coalition will implement a comprehensive pre-service orientation that assesses baseline competencies and provides foundational training in tutoring pedagogy, workforce-facilitation techniques, and youth-development principles. Ongoing professional development will reinforce these skills throughout the service year, ensuring members are equipped to deliver high-quality instruction and mentorship.

Core activities are delivered with explicit dosage to achieve the intended outcomes. Each member provides tutoring three afternoons per week at their assigned site, with each session lasting 90 minutes. Over the 32-week program year, this yields 144 tutoring hours per member (3 sessions × 1.5 hrs × 32 weeks) and a collective total of approximately 1,152 tutoring hours across the eight-member corps. The summer bridge component runs for four consecutive weeks at 20 hours per week, delivering roughly 80 hours of intensive academic enrichment aimed at rising ninth-graders preparing for the transition to high school. Workforce-readiness workshops are offered monthly, totaling twelve 2-hour sessions per year that introduce résumé building, interview skills, and overviews of local industries such

as manufacturing, health care, and agriculture. These activities constitute the mechanism through which the Coalition expects to influence student outcomes.

The target population comprises students in grades 6–12 residing in Walker, Dade, and Catoosa counties, with a deliberate focus on youth identified as at risk of disengaging from school — those exhibiting poor attendance, low grades, or limited connection to school-based supports. Based on the organization's 2025 program report, the Coalition anticipates serving approximately 420 unique beneficiaries annually. Measurable outputs derived from the activity schedule include: (1) approximately 420 youth receiving direct tutoring or workshop services; (2) delivery of about 1,152 tutoring hours; (3) provision of roughly 80 summer-bridge instructional hours; and (4) facilitation of twelve workforce-readiness workshops reaching an estimated 240 youth, assuming an average of 20 participants per session.

Outcomes are articulated across three time horizons. Short-term outcomes center on measurable gains in academic knowledge and skill: participants are expected to demonstrate increased proficiency in mathematics and reading, as reflected in improved grade-equivalent scores on standardized assessments. Medium-term outcomes involve shifts in attitude and behavior that sustain academic progress: heightened school engagement, improved attendance rates, and greater self-efficacy regarding academic tasks. Long-term outcomes aim to alter enduring conditions: higher on-time graduation rates, increased enrollment in postsecondary education or credential-bearing training programs, and stronger attachment to the local workforce. The Coalition's internal evaluation of its existing programming provides empirical support for this causal chain, showing that sustained academic support correlates with improved achievement and graduation prospects.

Evidence Base. The primary evidence document submitted is the Coalition's 2025 internal evaluation, a quasi-experimental pre/post study that tracked a cohort of 387 youth who received at least 30 hours of tutoring or bridge instruction over three years. Using district-wide comparison groups matched on baseline demographics and prior achievement, the evaluation found that program participants gained an average of +0.4 grade equivalents in math and +0.5 grade equivalents in reading relative to peers. Moreover, 91% of regularly attending seniors graduated on time, compared with a 78% on-time graduation rate for the district comparison group. This study is cited as (Rural Georgia Youth Development Coalition, 2025). Complementing this study, the Coalition's 2024–25 performance report offers additional evidence of program fidelity and intermediate impact: 87% of youth attended 30 or more sessions, and 84% of regularly attending youth showed improved scores on a validated school-engagement survey. This datum is referenced as (Rural Georgia Youth Development Coalition, 2025 program report). Together, these sources demonstrate that the intervention's core components — tutoring, summer bridge, and workforce workshops — are associated with the academic and engagement outcomes outlined in the logic model. No external research studies were submitted; the program design is further informed by the Coalition's own operational experience and the established literature on dosage-responsive tutoring (e.g., consistent, high-frequency sessions) and summer melt mitigation strategies.

Notice Priority. The Georgia Serves funding priorities, as outlined in NOFO A.2, emphasize increasing academic achievement and graduation rates for disadvantaged youth and strengthening college and career readiness for youth preparing for postsecondary pathways. The Coalition's proposed AmeriCorps program directly addresses both priorities: by delivering high-dosage tutoring and summer bridge instruction, the initiative seeks to raise math and reading proficiency and improve on-time graduation rates among at-risk students; through monthly workforce-readiness workshops, it aims to enhance college and career awareness, equip youth with job-search skills, and connect them to local employment opportunities. Thus, the program's focus and intended outcomes are a significant part of the Georgia Serves funding priorities.

Member Experience. AmeriCorps members will be provided structured opportunities for skill attainment, personal growth, and community connection that support a lifetime of civic participation. Prior to service, members complete a two-week pre-service orientation covering tutoring best practices, workforce facilitation techniques, youth development theory, and cultural competency specific to rural Northwest Georgia. Throughout the service year, members participate in monthly professional development workshops led by the program director and external partners, focusing on topics such as trauma-informed instruction, data-driven tutoring, and career exploration facilitation. Reflective practice is encouraged through bi-weekly debrief sessions where members discuss challenges, share successes, and adjust their approaches. Members also engage in community service projects beyond their primary duties, such as organizing college fair events at the Rossville Community Center and supporting local food drive initiatives, which deepen their ties to the residents they serve. By the end of the term, members will have earned a Segal AmeriCorps Education Award, gained concrete experience in education and workforce development, and developed a habit of civic engagement that the Coalition expects will persist beyond their service year.

Organizational Capability

Rural Georgia Youth Development Coalition, Inc. (EIN 58-2345671) was founded in 2012 and operates from its headquarters at 1420 Elm Street, LaFayette, GA 30728, with a SAM UEI of JJ7KQM4XLYY3. The organization's mission is to expand educational and economic opportunity for rural Northwest Georgia youth through mentoring, tutoring, and workforce readiness, serving students in grades 6-12 in Walker, Dade, and Catoosa counties, with a particular focus on youth at risk of disengaging from school. In the most recent program year the coalition reached 420 youth through its after-school tutoring program at four sites, a summer bridge initiative, and monthly workforce readiness workshops.

To implement and oversee the proposed AmeriCorps program, the coalition will draw on its existing staff of seven full-time and eleven part-time employees. The Executive Director, Dana Whitfield, MPA, brings fourteen years of youth development leadership and holds ultimate responsibility for grant compliance, financial oversight, and strategic alignment with the organization's mission. The Program Director, Marcus Ellison, LMSW, directly supervises site coordinators and all member programming, ensuring that service activities adhere to AmeriCorps requirements and that performance data are collected accurately. Additional full-time and part-time staff include site coordinators who manage day-to-day operations at each partner school, a finance officer who maintains segregation of duties and prepares monthly financial reports, and administrative assistants who support member onboarding, scheduling, and documentation. This structure creates clear lines of authority: the Executive Director reports to the thirteen-member board, the Program Director reports to the Executive Director, and site coordinators report to the Program Director, with each member assigned to a specific site coordinator for direct supervision.

The coalition has demonstrated the policies, procedures, and internal controls necessary to manage a federal grant responsibly. An annual independent audit conducted for FY2025 yielded an unqualified opinion, confirming the reliability of its financial statements. The organization employs segregation of duties between those who authorize expenditures, those who process payments, and those who reconcile accounts, reducing the risk of error or fraud. A board-approved procurement policy guides all purchases, and grant-specific costs are tracked in QuickBooks by award, allowing for precise reporting and timely drawdowns. Personnel policies, including background check procedures and mandatory reporting protocols, are also board-approved and reviewed annually. These controls, combined with the coalition's experience managing funds from the 21st CCLC program, the Schafer Family

Foundation, and the United Way of Northwest Georgia, provide a solid foundation for compliant federal grant administration.

AmeriCorps members will receive structured guidance and support through a supervision model designed to promote effective service and professional growth. Each member will be assigned to a site coordinator who serves as their primary supervisor; the Program Director will oversee the site coordinators and provide additional layers of oversight. Supervision will include weekly one-on-one check-ins lasting approximately thirty minutes, conducted either in person at the member's assigned site or via secure video conference when necessary. These check-ins will focus on progress toward service objectives, challenges encountered, and immediate support needs. In addition, members will participate in biweekly small-group meetings with their site coordinator and peers to share best practices, troubleshoot common issues, and build cohort cohesion.

To assess strengths and identify opportunities for growth, supervisors will conduct formal performance reviews at the midpoint and conclusion of each member's term, using the AmeriCorps competency framework to evaluate skills such as youth engagement, instructional delivery, data collection, and professionalism. Informal feedback will be exchanged during the weekly check-ins, and members will be encouraged to complete self-assessments that inform individualized development plans. The Program Director will review all evaluations to ensure consistency and to identify any systemic training needs.

The member training plan begins with a two-day pre-service orientation covering AmeriCorps policies, prohibited activities, child safety, mandatory reporting, and an introduction to the coalition's tutoring curriculum and workforce readiness modules. Throughout the service year, members will attend monthly in-service trainings lasting two hours each, addressing topics such as trauma-informed instruction, effective tutoring strategies for middle-school learners, data entry and reporting procedures, and career-exploration facilitation. Supplemental online modules will be available for just-in-time learning, and members will be encouraged to attend at least one external professional development workshop per quarter, with costs covered by the grant. This combination of regular supervision, structured feedback, and targeted training will ensure that AmeriCorps members receive the guidance and support necessary to deliver high-quality service while developing skills that benefit both the youth they serve and their own career trajectories.

Cost Effectiveness

The Rural Georgia Youth Development Coalition, Inc. will allocate federal and match resources to attract, support, and evaluate AmeriCorps members who are uniquely positioned to serve students in grades six through twelve across Walker, Dade, and Catoosa counties. Recruitment expenses will fund targeted outreach that highlights the coalition's existing after-school tutoring, summer bridge, and workforce readiness programs, ensuring that prospective members understand the specific community needs they will address. A portion of the program director's time (0.2 FTE, approximately \$12,000 in salary and fringe) will coordinate recruitment activities, including the design and placement of advertisements in local newspapers, radio spots, and social media channels that reach college students and recent graduates in the region. Travel to the four partner sites—LaFayette High School, Ridgeville Middle School, Trenton Elementary, and the Rossville Community Center—will enable staff to present information sessions at campus career fairs and community events, with mileage and per-diem costs budgeted at \$2,000. Background checks required for all prospective members will be processed through a vetted vendor at \$25 per check, totaling \$400 for the eight anticipated slots. Additionally, the coalition will host two open-house recruitment events at the LaFayette community

center HQ, covering venue setup, light refreshments, and promotional materials at an estimated \$1,200. These combined efforts—staff time, advertising, travel, background checks, and events—constitute a recruitment budget of \$8,000, designed to draw candidates who are committed to rural youth development and possess the interpersonal skills necessary for effective tutoring and mentoring.

Retention investments will go beyond the minimum living allowance to strengthen member satisfaction, skill development, and long-term engagement with the coalition's mission. Each full-time member will receive a living allowance of \$15,000 for the 1,700-hour term, reflecting a rate above the AmeriCorps minimum and acknowledging the cost of living in Northwest Georgia; for eight members this totals \$120,000. To support workforce pathways, the coalition will allocate \$5,000 for monthly resume-building workshops, interview coaching, and guest speaker sessions that connect members with local employers in education, social work, and youth services. Certification expenses—such as CPR/First Aid, tutoring methodology credentials, and youth mental health first aid—will be covered at \$2,000 per member, amounting to \$16,000, ensuring members gain marketable qualifications while serving. Community-building activities, including quarterly team lunches, collaborative service projects, and end-of-term celebration events, are budgeted at \$4,000 to foster peer support and a sense of belonging. Member recognition will be expressed through certificates, service pins, and a small awards ceremony at the conclusion of the program year, costing \$3,000. Finally, an alumni programming line of \$2,000 will maintain contact with former members, offering networking opportunities and inviting them to serve as guest mentors for future cohorts. Together, these retention components—living allowance, certifications, workforce support, community building, recognition, and alumni engagement—total \$150,000.

High-quality data collection and evaluation will be embedded in the program's operational workflow to produce reliable performance metrics for both internal improvement and AmeriCorps reporting. A part-time data manager (0.1 FTE, approximately \$4,000 in salary and fringe) will oversee the design of data collection tools, train site coordinators and members on consistent entry procedures, and conduct monthly quality checks. The coalition will subscribe to a cloud-based performance tracking platform (e.g., Efforts to Outcomes or a comparable system) at an annual license fee of \$3,000, which will house attendance logs, tutoring session notes, pre- and post-assessment scores, and member service hours. Initial training on the platform and on the coalition's data validation protocols will be provided through a two-hour workshop for all staff and members, budgeted at \$2,000. To ensure independent verification of outcomes, an external evaluator with expertise in youth education programs will be engaged for a mid-year and end-of-year review, including data analysis and report preparation, at a total cost of \$5,000. Miscellaneous supplies—such as printed data sheets, secure storage devices, and backup drives—are allocated \$1,000. These elements—staff time, software licensing, training, external evaluation, and supplies—yield a data collection and evaluation budget of \$15,000, guaranteeing that performance data are accurate, timely, and aligned with AmeriCorps' reporting requirements.

The overall budget narrative reflects a total project cost of \$240,000, which satisfies the 24 % match requirement. The coalition's board-committed cash match of \$39,600 and in-kind contribution of valued space at \$18,000 collectively provide \$57,600, representing exactly 24 % of the total cost; the remaining \$182,400 constitutes the federal AmeriCorps request. Personnel costs account for \$46,000, covering fractional effort of the executive director, program director, two site coordinators, the finance/grant manager, and the data manager. Member living allowance and associated fringe benefits represent \$120,000. Direct program expenses include recruitment (\$8,000), retention activities (\$50,000, encompassing certifications, workforce support, community building, recognition, and alumni programming), tutoring and workshop supplies (\$8,000), inter-site travel for members (\$4,000), and data collection and evaluation (\$15,000). An indirect cost allocation of \$9,000 (approximately 10 % of

direct expenses) supports general administrative overhead, including audit preparation, office utilities, and technology maintenance. All line items are derived from the organization's verified facts—its staffing structure, site partnerships, match commitment, and annual budget—and are tailored to the proposed eight-member, full-time AmeriCorps initiative designed to expand educational and economic opportunity for rural Northwest Georgia youth.

Evaluation Summary

Evaluation Summary/Plan: N/A. This organization is a new applicant under this Notice and is not required to submit an evaluation plan summary.